EMB-101: Emergence of Bangladesh
Class - 3

From Origins of Bengal Sultanates to the Battle of Polashi (1204-1757) : Society, Religion and Politics

BRAC UNIVERSITY

Inspiring Excellence

Overview of the Class

- Rise and expansion of Islam in Bengal
- Accommodation of Islam in Bengal
- Bengal under Delhi Sultanate
- Bengal under Mughal rule
- Understanding North-Indian Hegemony
- Quasi-independent Bengal
- The Footprint of British in Bengal
- The battle of Polashy

Backdrop of Muslim Rule in Bengal

- Formation of Bengal Delta was an ongoing process from the very ancient period
- Bengal, a flood plain land, became the hub for new settlement and human migration
- It was naturally accommodative instead of being stubborn
- Combination of various races, religions, cultures and customs
- North-Indian hegemony was not a religious factor, rather was a part of expansion of imperialism (happened in Morya rule, Gupta rule, Pala rule, Sena rule, even during Muslim period)
- The conversion/adoption/accommodation of religion was rarely/not done by force
- Ancient/medieval kingdoms/regional powers rarely attacked the people of other religions, they rather attacked the kings of the same belief/other beliefs for expansion of kingdom.
- For instance, after the death of Bokhtiar Khilji in 1206 (he was killed by his officer), there was a clash even amongst the disciples of Bokhtiar for regional power.
- Siraj Ud Daula was also toppled down by a Muslim who was Mir Jafar.
- Therefore, common Muslim, Hindu, Buddhist people did not have any involvement in this process of power transfer. - Rajat Roy, Palashir Shorojontro o Sekaler Somaj (Conspiracy of Polashy and the society of the than Bengal)

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

- **Ikhtiar-Ud-Din Muhammad-Bin Bokhtiar-Khilji conquered Bihar in 1203 and Gour in 1204 but Islam reached in ancient Bengal in 8th century**
- **Silver coin of Harun-ar-Rashid, an Abbasid Caliph, has been found at Paharpur which was issued in 788. Historians argue that it was either carried by a sea farer Arab merchant (as cited by Abdul Momin Choudhury*, Abdul Karim**) or by a Sufi (Islamic preacher), as cited by Enamul Haque***.**
- **Therefore, it is evident that Islam reached to ancient Bengal as early as eighth century, which was three Hundred years before the conquest of Bokhtiar Khilji.**

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

There are four conventional theories of Islamization in India/Bengal:

1. Religion by sword

Criticism: If there was mass forcible conversion, then the growth of Muslim population was supposed to be more in Sultanate period, but during five hundred years of Muslim rule, Hindu population remained much higher than Muslims. Even it continued till the mid of British era.

Furthermore, Census in British period shows that the number of Muslims in Eastern Bengal and Western Punjab were much more higher than Delhi which was the powerful center of Muslim rule. It had only 10-15% Muslims compared to Hindus. – Eaton, The rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier : 1204-1760

As the 1901 *Census of India* put it:

None of these [eastern] districts contains any of the places famous as the head-quarters of Muhammadan rulers. Dacca was the residence of the Nawab for about a hundred years, but it contains a smaller proportion of Muslims than any of the surrounding districts, except Faridpur. Malda and Murshidabad contain the old capitals, which were the center of Musalman rule for nearly four and a half centuries, and yet the Muslims form a smaller proportion of the population than they do in the adjacent districts of Dinajpur, Rajshahi, and Nadia.

Census of India, 1901, vol. 6, *The Lower Provinces of Bengal and Their Feudatories* (Calcutta: Bengal Secretariat Press, 1902), 156

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

There are four conventional theories of Islamization in Bengal:

2. Religion by immigration

Migrated, married and settled

Criticism: A large number of immigrants came from Arab, Persia and other countries but the number does not seem to be higher than mass conversion because most of the immigrants settled down in the city areas

3. Religion by patronization

Happened in many cases, many upper cast Hindus also accepted Islam

Criticism: Similar counter-arguments of the 1st one because there was less possibility of being patronized from the periphery where conversion mostly happened.

Why did the Muslim population increase faster in British era despite their miserable condition?

4. Religion by social liberation

Getting rid of the domination of upper class Hindu/cast system.

Partially true but it also did not influence the mass conversion. If that was the case , then the Eastern Bengal and Western Punjab were supposed to have less conversion than upper-Gangetic area. In reality, those orthodox Hindu areas, had less conversion

In ancient or medieval era, Islam mostly emerged as a religion of monotheism against polytheism instead of fraternity against cast system.

Why did the Muslim population increase faster in British era despite their miserable condition?

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

"Many early Bengali saints, whose shrines are located in a large arc extending from the Twenty- four Parganas and Khulna Districts in the south, through Noakhali, Comilla and Sylhet Districts in the east, are associated with the clearing of the jungle and the teaching of wet-rice agriculture, along with, of course, the preaching of Islam. It appears, then, that in this earliest phase of the Islamization of Bengal Muslim pioneers took part in the settlement of this land, and that some of them actually organized the indigenous peoples for purposes of clearing the land for rice cultivation. Overtime, these same indigenous peoples seem in turn to have sanctified those pioneers by whose hands they had become integrated in to an expanding agrarian economy."

- Richard M. Eaton, cited in the Islamic Heritage of Bengal (Edited by George Michell), Page-26

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

- **Therefore, Islamization happened due to immigration and mass conversion influenced by various reasons.**
- **Sufis, Saints and Ulemas played the most important rule in the mass conversion process**
- **Conversion happened from Buddhists, and both from upper and lower class Hindus**
- **It took nearly a millennium to form majority of Muslim in Bengal or todays Bangladesh.**
- **This increase became clearly visible in the census of 1872-1941. As J. A. Vas , quoting the census Report of 1901, states,**

"The Mohammedan population is growing at a relatively much greater rate than the Hindus. This is not due to conversion, of which very few are recorded. The greater fecundity of Mohammedans is explained by the prevalence of polygamy and widow marriage, the lesser inequality between the ages of husband and wife. The greater nutritiousness of dietary and their greater material prosperity" (District Gazetteer, Rangpur, 1911, p,44)

Root and Route of Islam in Bengal

Increase of the Muslim population in the period 1872—1941.

Census	Total population in India	Total Muslims in India	Total population of Bengal Proper	Muslim population in Bengal Proper	Hindu population in Bengal Proper.	Remarks.
1872	255 million		36,769,735	16,370,967	18,102,348 16.8 million actual.	Many Animists were enumerated with Hindus. The actual Hindu population was 16.8 million.
1881		49.95 million 19.97 p.c. of total.	35,607,628	17,863,411	17,254,120	Fall of total population because of separation of Sylhet and its inclusion to Assam. Its population was 10 lakhs in 1881 and 11 lakhs in 1891.
1891	287,223,431		38,277,338	19,582,481	18,068,655	
1901				21.907,980	20,150,541	In 10 years Muslim increase was 10 % and Hindu increase 4.8 %
1911				24,237,228	20,945,379	In 10 years Muslim increase 10.4 and Hindu 3.9 %
1921						
1931						
1941	388.9 million	94.45 million 24.28 % of total population.	70 million approximately	37 million approximately.	31 million approximately.	Because of political passions both Hindus and Muslims inflated their numbers

N.B.—(1) In 70 years (1872—1941) Indian Population increased by 52 per cent.
(2) In 60 years (1881—1941) Indian Muslim population nearly doubled (from49.95 million to 94.45 million).
(3) In 70 years (1872—1941) Bengali Muslims more than doubled (16 million to 37 million); 131.2 p.c. increase.
(4) In 1872 Bengali Muslim population was half a million Hindus; in 1891 they susrspassed Hindus by a million and half.
(5) In 70 years (1872—1941) Hindu increase was highest in Ea(17 million to 31 million) 14 million i.e. 82.3 p.c. increase.
(6) The increase of Muslim population was highest in Eastern Bengal.

The Origin and Growth of the Muslims 59

Muhammad Abdul Rahim, Social and Cultural History of Bengal (1201-1576), Vol-1, p.59)

Bengali language and literature

The evolution of Bengali from Sanskrit and Arab-Persian languages

Ma-Huan, a Chinese traveler visited Bengal in 1433 commented "although Persian was spoken by some in the Muslim court, the language in universal use is Bengali".

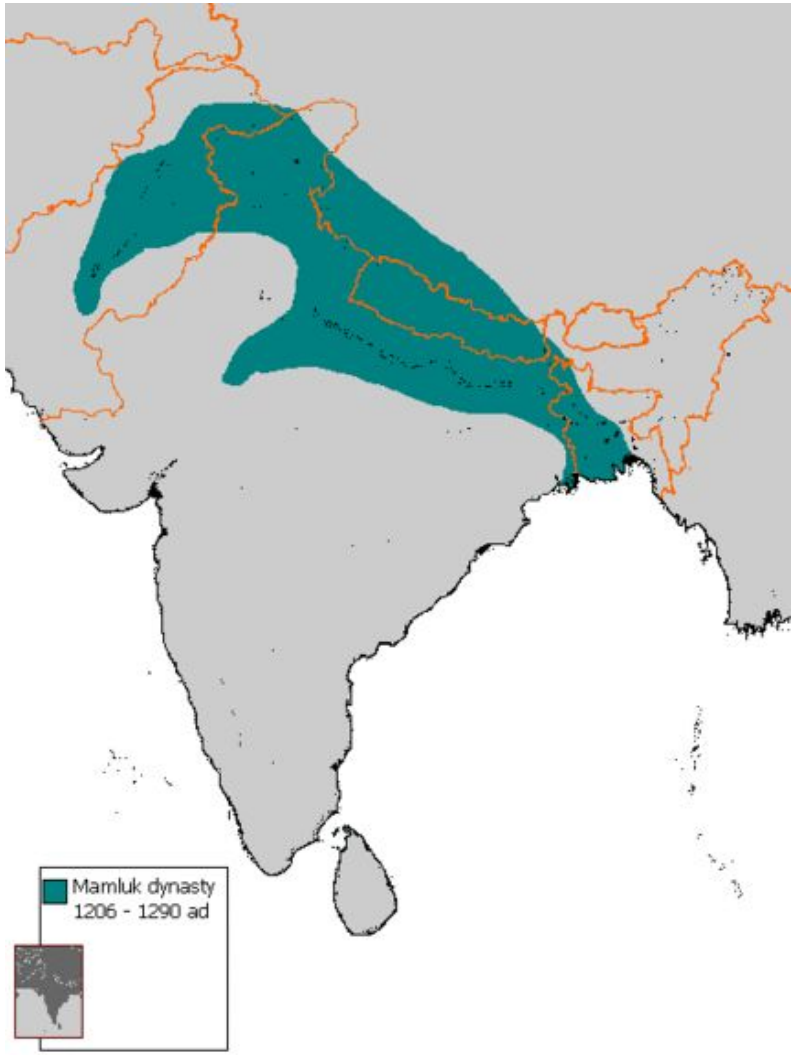
- Richard M. Eaton, cited in the Islamic Heritage of Bengal (Edited by George Michell), Page-29

Development of Bengali language and literature

Muslim Conquest of Bengal



Bokhtiar Khilji issued coins by using both Sanskrit and Arabic



- **Muslim conquest happened in Bihar in 1203, and in Nodia and Lakhnauti in 1904 when Sen king Laksman Sen was defeated by Bakhtiyar Khilji, a military officer of Ghurid dynasty of North India**
- **Though Muslim conquest took place in 1204, the people of Bengal came in contact with Muslim people and Islam at least in 8th century.**
- **Therefore, at least a slow pace of conversion and naturalization was already going on.**

Initial Stage of Muslim Rule

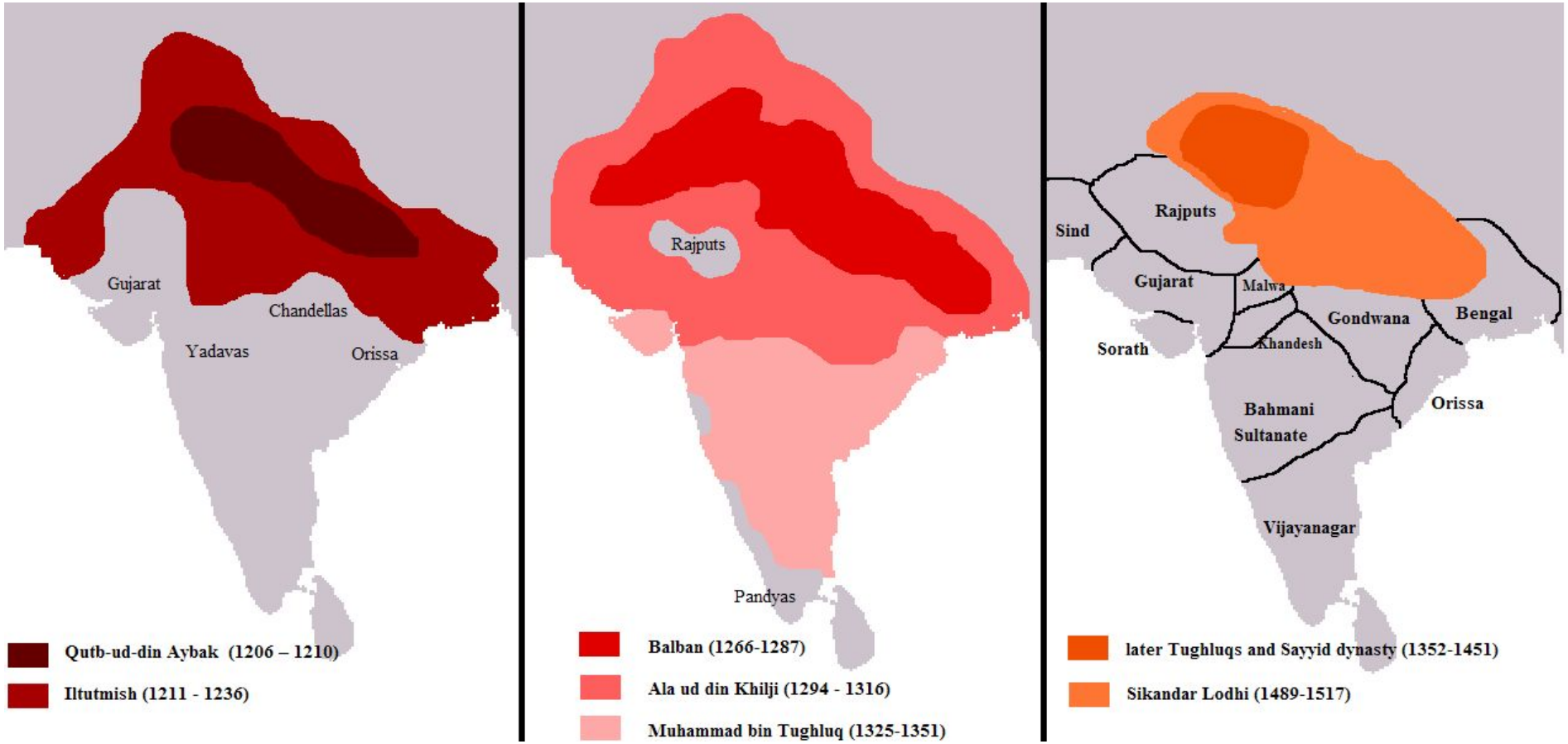


Coins issued by Iwaj Khilji

- **Six years of internal conflict**
- **Ghiyas-Ud-Din Iwaz Khilji (1212-1227), a Governor of Delhi Sultan Iltutmish (a ruler of Mamluk dynasty**

Bengal under Delhi Sultans

- **North Indian Hegemony continued**
- **Bengal was a province of Delhi up to 1338**
- **Bengal used to be known as the city of rebellion due to its frequent revolt against Delhi Sultans**



The First Independent Muslim ruler of Bengal

- Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah was the first Independent Muslim sultan (1338-1350)
- Sonargaon was his capital
- Constructed a royal road from Chandpur to Chottogram
- Patron of art, literature, culture, and Sufism



Coins of Fakhruddin Mubarak Shah



Moroccan Traveller Ibn Batuta Came to Bengal in 1345 – 46.

Visited Hazrat Shah Jalal

Independent Sultanate in Bengal

Ilyas Shahi dynasty (1342-1487 except some short interregnums)

- Established by Shamsuddin Ilyas Shah (1342-1357)
- Initially ruled Lakhnauti, later conquered Satgaon and Sonargaon
- He united Bengal and titled himself as Shah –E –Bangala or Sultan-E-Bangala
- Pandua, a city of Maldah district, was the capital
- He promoted the participation of local people in the administration
- Another prominent ruler was Giasuddin Azam Shah (1393-1409)
- GAS was the patron of art and Bengali language and literature. For instance, Shah Sagir wrote Yusuf Julekha in response to the request of Sultan. Ramayana got translated into Bengali by Krittibas
- Ilias Shahi rulers were the patron of Muslim art and culture

Independent Sultanate in Bengal

Ilyas Shahi architecture



Adina Mosque, the largest mosque in Indian-sub Continent at that time was built by Sikandar Shah



Shat Gombuj Mosque was built by Khan Jahan Ali, a governor of Nasiruddin Mahmud Shah

Independent Sultanate in Bengal

Husain Shahi dynasty (1494-1538)

- Established by Alauddin Husain Shah
- Golden Age of Bengal
- Conquered Assam, Kamrup, Teppera, Jajnagar and Chittagong
- Gaur/Lakhnauti, a city of Maldah district, was the capital
- He and his successors promoted the participation of local Hindu people in the administration. His Private Secretary Rupa Goswami and several ministers were from Hindu religion, specially the followers of Vaishnavism.
- Religious tolerance and pluralism
- Monoshamongal was written by Vijoy Gupta
- Maha Bharat was translated into Bengali
- They patronized the development of Vaishnavism
- Appointed Vaishnavis and liberal Hindus in their court



Coins of Alauddin Husain Shah

Mughal rule in Bengal

- Disintegration of Bengal Sultanate, and Nort-Indian hegemony
- Rise of Sher Sha Sur and Karrani dynasty
- Babur started Mughal Rule in Delhi in 1526
- Akbar conquered Bengal in 1576, and consolidated Mughal rule in Bengal
- Mughal supremacy was challenged by regional Bengali chieftains or Baro-Bhuiyaans



Palace of Isa Kha

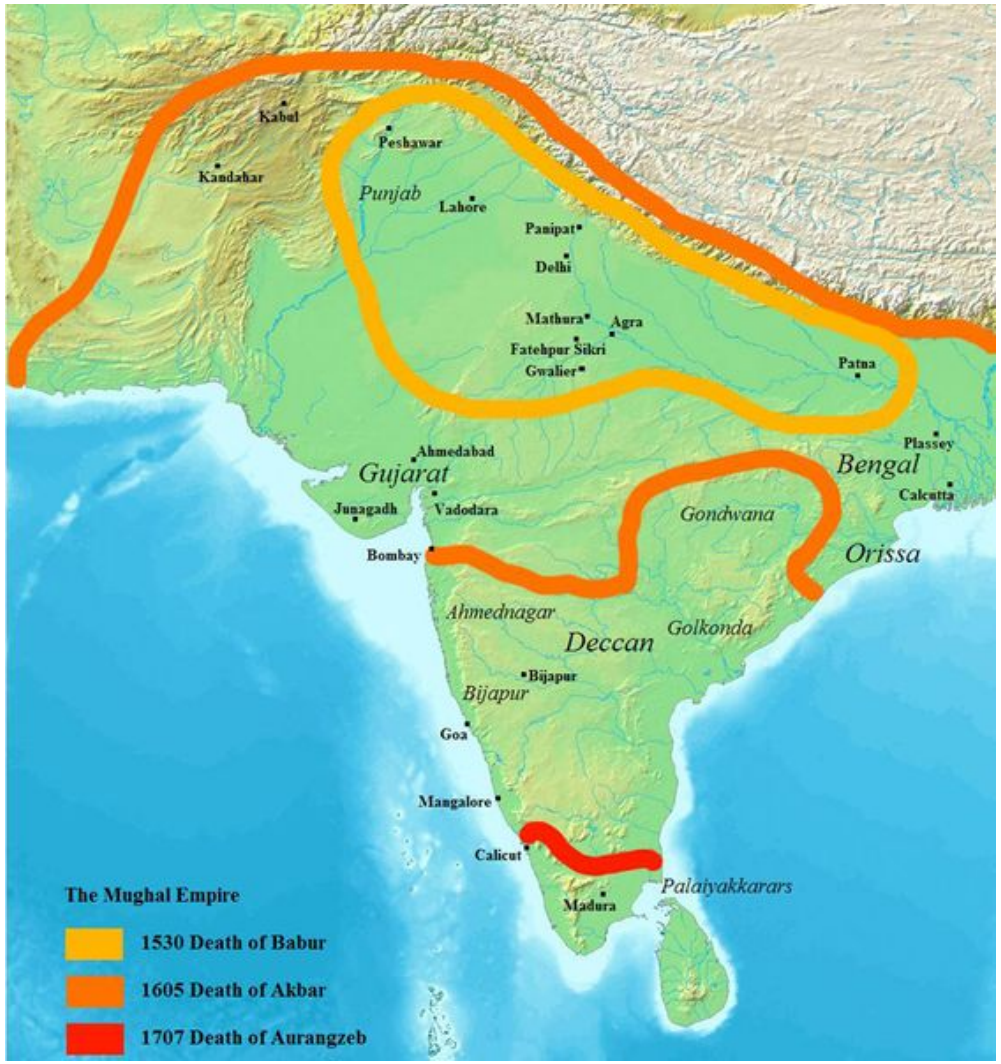
at Sonargaon, Narayangonj



Isa Kha, one of the Baro-Bhuiyaas

Mughal rule in Bengal

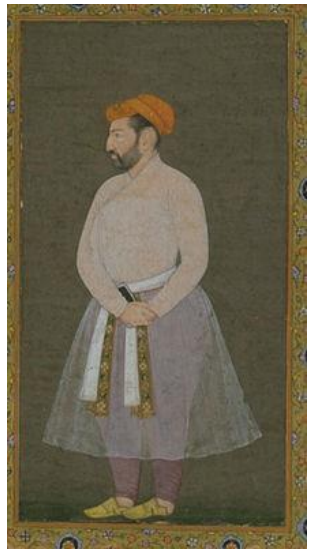
The trajectory of Mughal rule in Bengal



Bengal under Mughal Subedar or Governors



Prince Shah Shuja



Mir Jumla



Shaista Khan



Prince Azimuddin

Backdrop of Bengal coming under Nawabs



Murshid Quli Khan



Alivardi Khan



Sirajuddaula



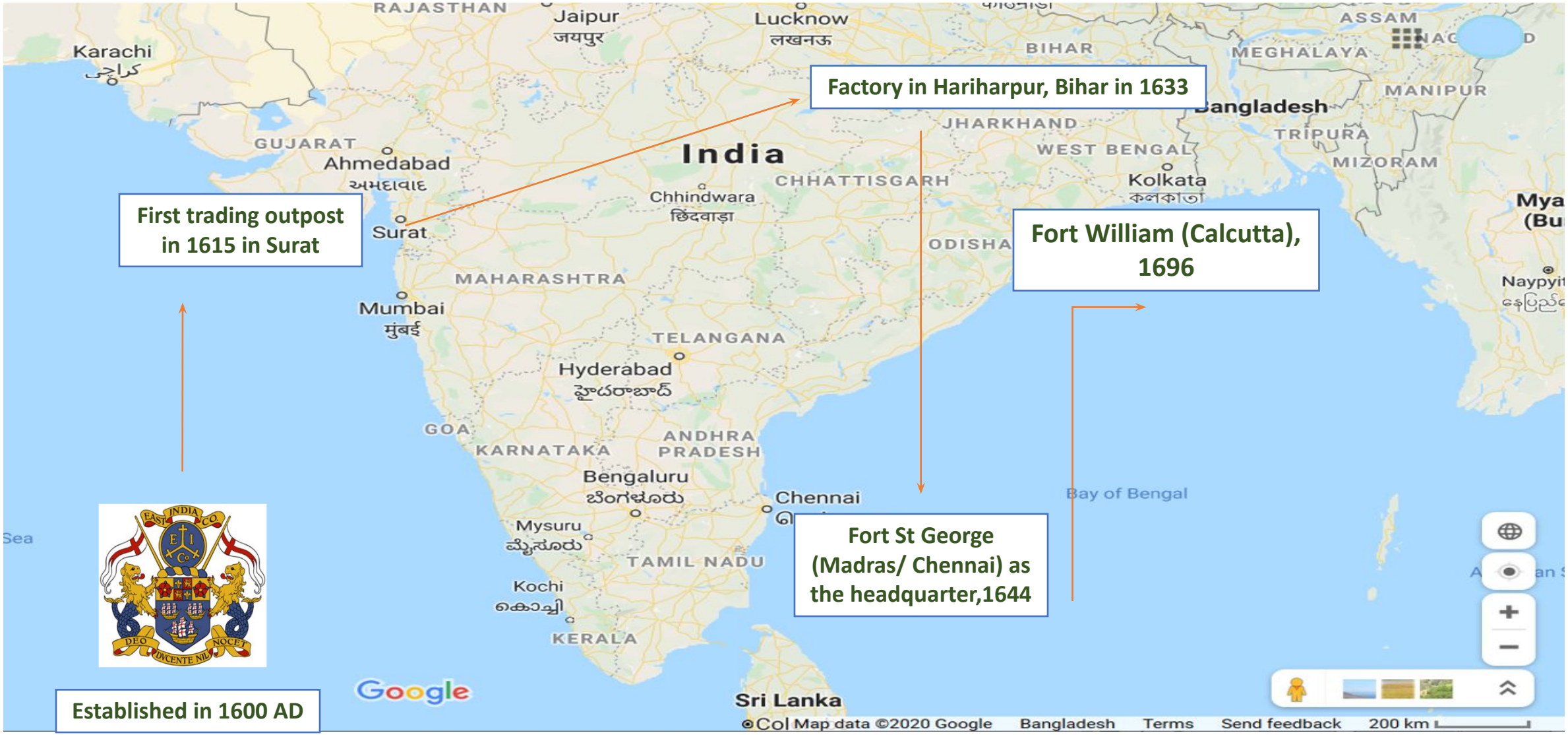
Lalbagh Fort, a Mughal architecture

- **Emperor Akbar was one of the greatest rulers in Asia**
- **Patron of arts, culture and education**
- **Pluralism in the society and administration, and religious tolerance**
- **Mughal India was wealthier than contemporary European states**
- **Bengal turned into one of the wealthiest province of Mughal Empire**
- **Decay of Mughal central authority after the death of Aurangajeb in 1707**
- **Bengal turned int a quasi-independent entity during Murshid Quli Khan**

Bengal under Nawabs

- Central Mughal rule contentiously suffered from internal clash and weakness
- European traders took the chance of weakness
- European traders built forts, maintained mercenary army/Sipahi, often took part in the palace conspiracy
- European trade created an affluent and wealthy business class, who also often took part in palace conspiracy
- Battle of Polashy in 1757

British East India Company in India

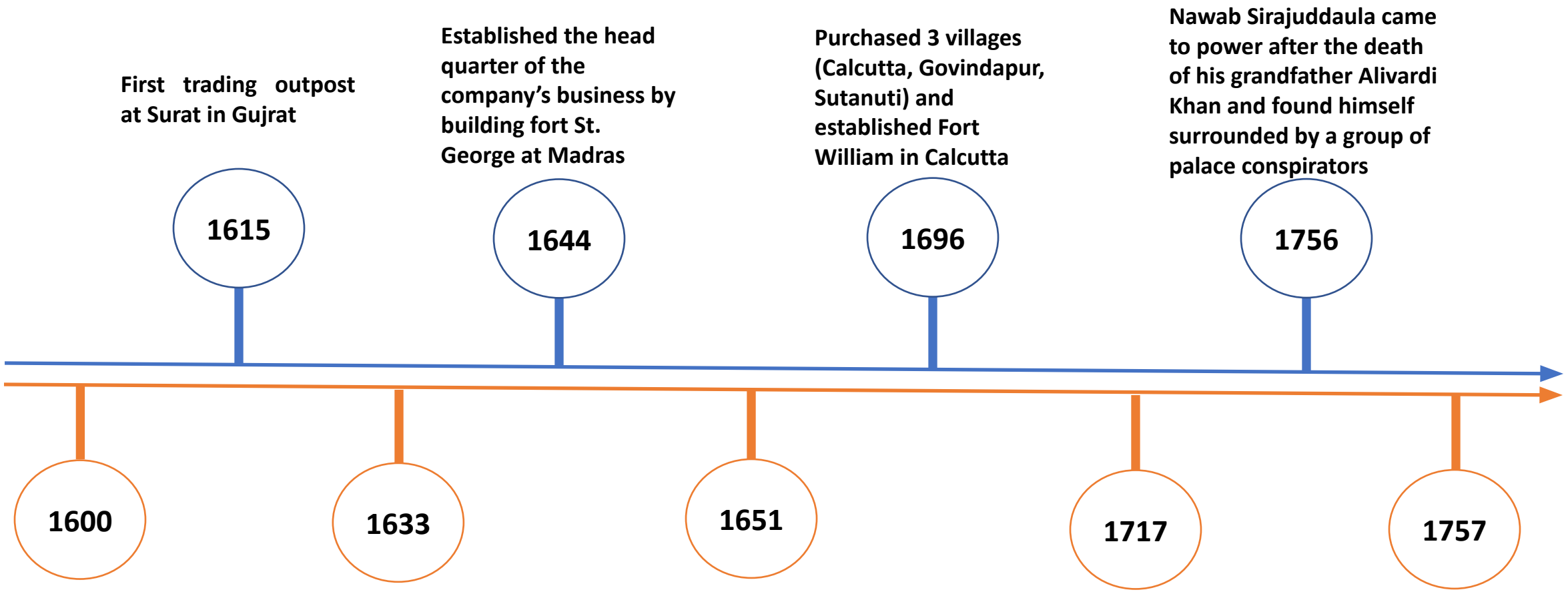


Fort William in Calcutta



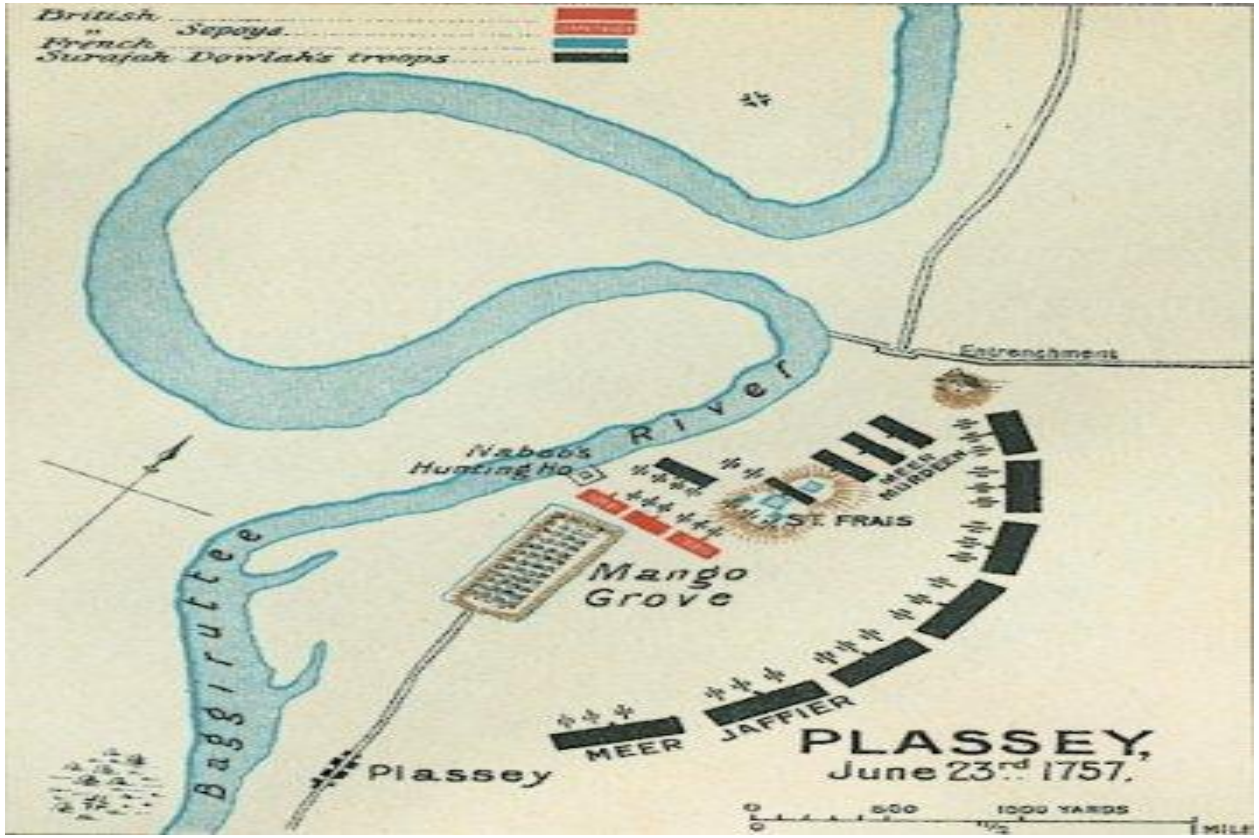


Timeline: British East India Company Takes over Bengal



The Company and the Conquest of Bengal

Robert Clive conspires with Mir Jafar and others in Bengal against Sirajuddaula, and defeats him in the battle of Polashi





The Masterminds of the Conspiracy



Mir Jafar and his son Miran



Robert Clive



Robert Clive meeting with Mir Jafar after Polashi, by Francis Hayman



Mir Jafar and his son Miran delivering the treaty of 1757 to William Watts (chief of the Kasimbazar factory of the British East India Company)

Aftermath of the Battle

Nawab Sirajuddaula was defeated and killed

Mir Jafar became the puppet Nawab

Company became the king maker

Battle of Buxar and the defeat of Mir Kasim

Colonial rule started which lasted for 190 years

Company Takes over the Diwani



Immediately after the battle of Buxar, Shah Alam II granted the Diwani right over Bengal to the East India Company in 1765, allowing it to collect revenue

Aspirations for an Empire

After the battle of Buxar, Clive wrote to England:

"We have at last arrived at that critical Conjuncture, which I have long foreseen,' he wrote to the chairman of the EIC. 'I mean that Conjuncture which renders it necessary for us to determine whether we can, or shall, take the whole [Mughal Empire] to ourselves."

Source: Dalrymple, William, *The Anarchy: The East India Company, Corporate Violence, and the Pillage of an Empire* (New York: Bloomsbury Publishing, 2019), pp. 215.

Suggested Readings

Required Reading:
Salahuddin, A. F. (2004). *Bangladesh National Culture and Heritage.* Dhaka : IUB.
Pages: 95-115

Recommended Readings:

Rahim, M. A. (1963). *Social and Cultural History of Bengal .* Karachi: Pakistan Historical Society.

Sengupta, N. (2011). *Land of Two Rivers*. India: Penguin Books

Eaton, R. M. (1996). *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier: 1204-1760.* USA: UCL Press.

Rahim, M. A., Choudhury, A. M., Mahmud, A. B. M. & Islam, S. (2005). *Bangladesher Etihash (History of Bangladesh).* Dhaka: Nouruj Kitabistan.

Ahmed, R. (ed.). (2001). *Understanding Bengal Muslims.* Oxford University Press.

Next Class Preview

British India (1757-1857): Colonialism, Reform and Resistance